NewsBank inc.

Only one of thirteen California lawmakers came to this affordability hearing

October 17, 2025 | Sacramento Bee, The: Web Edition Articles (CA)
Author: Kate Wolffe, The Sacramento Bee | Section: capitol_alert | 926 Words
OpenURL Link

A THIN SHOWING FOR AFFORDABILITY

In December, Assembly Speaker Robert Rivas

said affordability should be the California Legislature's top priority.

In April, his office announced they'd be creating four select committees targeting high cost drivers in California . At the time, Rivas spokesperson Nick Miller

said the committees were "strategic" and "not performative."

On Wednesday, one of those committees, the Select Committee on Childcare Costs , met for the second time, at the Burbank City Hall Chambers

in Burbank .

Of the 13 members, only one showed up: Committee Co-chair Cecilia Aguiar-Curry

, D- Winters .

Aguiar-Curry held court for over three hours, hearing from state agencies as well as childcare providers and the organizations and unions that work with them.

She asked questions about how childcare systems are integrated into emergency planning efforts, and heard testimony from local providers, already cash-strapped, about how they were affected financially by the LA wildfires.

Childcare is one of the largest cost drivers for families in the state. According to the Public Policy Institute of California , "the full-time cost of preschool care is 6 percent to 18 percent-and infant care is 8 percent to 28 percent-of median incomes."

Four of the lawmakers on the committee represent districts in the Los Angeles area, where the meeting was held: Assembly members Jesse Gabriel

, D- Encino , Sharon Quirk-Silva

, D- Fullerton , Pilar Schiavo

, D- Chatsworth , and Jose Solache

, D- Lakewood . Staff from Gabriel and Schiavo's offices said the lawmakers couldn't attend due to previous commitments. Quirk-Silva and Solache's offices didn't respond to a request for comment.

Rivas also declined to comment. Miller said member schedules are impacted during recess, and it's important to keep the process going.

Aguiar-Curry echoed the sentiment, sharing in an emailed statement that the state "can't afford to lose

momentum."

Panels during the interim study recess don't normally draw a large crowd, but this month's panels on public safety, sea level rise and the economy, and fisheries and aquaculture drew larger crowds.

Cristina Alvarado

, executive director of the Child Care Alliance of Los Angeles , spoke at the hearing and said in an interview afterward that she appreciated having an "intimate" audience with Aguiar-Curry, because it made people more comfortable.

Regardless, as a long-time advocate, she said she's used to an unpredictable audience.

"Sometimes we get unlucky and we have one or two legislators showing up at a committee meeting where there's people testifying, and sometimes the whole committee is there."

BOOSTS FOR TUBBS IN L.G. RACE

Lt. Gov. candidate Michael Tubbs

has notched some campaign victories this week in an endorsement and fundraising support from allies.

The progressive Working Families Party on Tuesday endorsed Tubbs, the former mayor of Stockton who now advises Gov. Gavin Newsom

on economic mobility.

And author and political commentator Steve Phillips

announced his independent committee to boost Tubbs in next year's statewide elections has so far raised $2 million of a $4 million goal by the end of the year.

Tubbs still lags behind two Democratic opponents in fundraising. According to the most recent campaign finance reports, state Treasurer Fiona Ma

has $4.5 million in the bank and Josh Fryday

, Newsom's volunteerism czar, has $1.4 million. Former Sausalito Mayor Janelle Kellman

, also a Democrat, has $130,000 on-hand

During his single term as mayor, Tubbs made waves for piloting universal basic income in Stockton . The program has been seen as a success - a study found recipients of the $500-per-month stipends saw improvements in employment, physical health and emotional well-being.

"It's time to turn the page from a status quo and invest in a bench of young diverse leaders who are more representative of California today than 40 years ago with leaders like Michael, who have demonstrated their commitment to public service with a proven track record of achievements," WFP California Director Jane Kim

said in her endorsement of Tubbs.

- Nicole Nixon

GRAY'S GOT A LEG UP

Rep. Adam Gray

, regarded as one of the nation's most vulnerable House incumbents, had $1 million on hand for his 2026 campaign as of September 30 , according to a new Federal Election Commission report.

Gray's Central Valley district could look a lot different next year, and more favorable for Democrats , if voters approve Proposition 50 in November.

Gray also reported $53,339 in debts or obligations, mostly money owed to fundraising and research firms.

His donors included Democratic House leaders and a wide variety of political action committees. Among them were PACs from WalMart, American Sugarbeet Growers , the National Chicken Council , firefighters, Realtors, insurance and health care firms. Gray won his House seat last year over incumbent Republican John Duarte

by 187 votes.

Those vying to topple Gray in 2026 include Ceres Mayor Javier Lopez

, a Republican who reported $19,820 on hand but $14,084 in debts or obligations, most of it owed to a Washington, D.C. firm for consulting and fundraising.

Also in the race is Republican Vin Kruttiventi

who reported $164,520 on hand, and $807,799 in debts or obligations, mostly involving personal funds he has used to finance his campaign.

- David Lightman

QUOTE OF THE DAY

"The Trump administration may think that an X post is the end-all, be-all, but I'm here to tell them, the law still stands."

-Attorney General Rob Bonta

, regarding an August X post from EPA Administrator Lee Zeldin

that announced the cancellation of the Solar for All program, during a news conference about suing the EPA over the cancellation.

Best of The Bee:

California to start selling $11 insulin pens in January via Lia RussellCA Attorney General sues to reinstate Solar for All funds from US EPA via Kate WolffeKatie Porter breaks silence on damaging viral videos: 'Not going to back down' via Nicole Nixon

Copyright (c) 2025 The Sacramento Bee

- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Wolffe, K. (2025, October 17). Only one of thirteen California lawmakers came to this affordability hearing*Sacramento Bee, The: Web Edition Articles (CA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1A3C93E2207FE688.